Through a Window

By Angela Johnson

NIA: I don't believe in God. Not right now. Not at this minute. But . . . When they cut Nick Gorden down from the upper stairwell outside the chem lab, a storm had just come up over the lake. You know the kind: lightning, rain, and wind that rips the roofs off buildings.

They were gentle when they took Nick away. The paramedics put him on the stretcher like he was a baby. I didn't see the rest, the cops and all. I only watched through a second-floor window as they took my best friend away from me and here and this place . . . forever . . .

INTRODUCTION

Sometimes we think we know someone because we see him or her almost every day. Then something happens to make us realize we didn't know that person at all. The death of a best friend is different than the death of a parent or spouse; there are no sympathy cards that quite fit the bill. There's no term for this loss and folks expect an abbreviated mourning period and offer a different, lighter brand of sympathy. It's almost like you are living your life as a spectator . . . just watching . . . Through a Window by Angela Johnson

NIA: I tell my therapist that there had to be a storm the day Nick died. Something cataclysmic and ugly had to happen. If the sun had been shining, afterward maybe I would have cried and thought about how Nick just missed a day at the park. But as it happened, nature stepped in again. Somebody had to cry for Nick. The sky and his mother did that day. My eyes stayed dry.

It's all about Nick. All of it. The therapy, the dreams, the way I can't cry . . . Nick's favorite song was the old Sly & the Family Stone tune called "Everybody Is a Star." He sang it all the time. *(sing lines from the song here – See links to song and lyrics at the end of this selection)* Wrote and tagged buildings everywhere with it, but in the end he didn't believe

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it, I guess. It was the song Nick's uncle was singing right before he died in Vietnam. Nick's mom got all her brother's belongings - clothes, records, dog tags - from one of the guys in his platoon.

It used to drive me crazy listening to those old records with scratches and jumps in them, but Nick said the scratches were in his head - he knew every one of them and they were like old friends. I never told Nick those records bothered me. Now I wished I had, 'cause at least it would have been one more conversation we had had.

I used to be envious of Nick, 'cause he was the person that everybody said hello to in the halls. He always smiled and seemed to sail along halls that had nothing but fear in them (to me, at least). In class pictures he always smiled. In his family pictures he always smiled. I overheard his mom on the phone once call him sweet and good-natured.

But I found out something about Nick a week before he died that got me all turned around, and I'd known Nick since first grade. We had been each other's one and only friend since he'd followed me under the monkey bars after I stolen Josh Neil's lunch. Nick had crawled under and sat behind me while I munched. He stared at me until I gave him a Fruit Roll-Up to go away. He ate it, kept staring, and stayed.

The next day the same thing, only this time I'd taken pudding out of Heather Longchamp's backpack 'cause she'd sat on me in front of the whole first grade. Plus she always had butterscotch. We finally got caught a week later. My mom dragged me out of the office mumbling that I was already a criminal.

Nick told the principal he'd taken the lunches and I said I'd taken them. Okay, we were tight; so why didn't I understand that even though Nick was somebody people smiled at and waved to, nobody knew anything about him? Sometimes they couldn't even remember his name. Nick said it. He was the invisible man.

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The week before they took him out on a stretcher with his face covered, Mr. Miles (in civics class) couldn't remember his name or that he had even been in that class. I think Nick could have taken that if Heather (no longer eating pudding--- a definite anorexic) hadn't started laughing that he'd been going to school for years and nobody ever knew his name.

I wanted to hit her. Break those skinny, skinny cheerleader arms and that big-toothed smile she only used to torture people. Everybody laughed but me and Mr. Miles, who just looked confused and a little sorry he'd opened his mouth. Nick was even laughing. I spent the rest of the day with a stomachache, not able to look Nick in the eye. Later that night he laughed that invisible people had to have a sense of humor. I didn't think that was funny.

I wasn't invisible myself. I was just visible enough to be let out of conversation purposely - just visible enough to be picked on for my bad skin, nonexistent fashion sense, and biggest crime of all: I was smarter than anyone in my class and I had the nerve to be female.
(Long beat)

I went over to Nick's house after the police and [everyone] had gone back to their lives. At first I was going to knock on the door, but then I couldn't face Miss Gorden. Her eyes would be puffy, her face tired and sad, her body drooping. I climbed into the open hall window on the side of the house. It's the way me and Nick came in most of the time anyway.

I could hear Miss Gorden crying two rooms down. She sounded like a little kid. I almost started crying too. That would have been a good thing. That would have helped. But instead, I just ducked into Nick's room.

His baseball and Greenpeace posters jumped out at me and stabbed me in the heart. I used to listen to guys at school talking basketball as Nick's eyes glowed. I'd think: This

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time he's going to say something, talk about what happened in some game somewhere. But he never did, and none of the group ever asked. I curled up on the bed and in a minute was asleep. When I woke up a few hours later, the sun was going down and Miss Gorden must have come in and taken Nick's favorite blanket off his chair and covered me in it. I put it over my head and inhaled Nick, then crawled out the way I came in and walked the street-lit sidewalks.

At breakfast yesterday my dad said, "Do you want to go to another school?" I bit down hard on my apple without looking at him, then slurped my orange juice so that I couldn't hear him if he asked me again. He asked again. So I grabbed a piece of toast and hoped it was as loud as the apple had been. He shook his head and looked at my mom, who was looking again for signs that I was so depressed I'd go the way Nick had. Finally, though, they started picking up the breakfast dishes and left me alone. I'd have to get used to alone.

I stood beside Miss Gorden when they put her son in the ground. I fought the urge to scream when the casket was lowered. I should have screamed. There were eight people there: Miss Gorden, my parents and me, the school principal, and three people that I've never seen before. Again, I wanted to scream. Nobody from school came. Not one classmate. Not even to get out of those halls from hell. Everyone cried but me.

When the service ended, Miss Gorden turned on the [CD] she'd told me to bring. She sat next to Nick's grave and smiled as "Everyone Is A Star" echoed through the cemetery. And all I could think as I got into my mom's minivan was that Nick probably wouldn't even be mad that the last time he heard his song it was on a CD.

For a week, the halls and classes got quite when I walked through them. It was like I was carrying a plague that would only infect others if they talked around you. They all just stayed away.

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The second week, though, it started. The questions: Why? And why there? Did I expect it? Did he talk about it? I would swallow what I wanted to say and never answer. Did they want me to put in a paragraph or less (while looking appropriately sad) how someone I loved more than anyone on the planet had lived his life, then ended it? Especially to people who couldn't give a damn whether he lived or died before. Had most of the pack creatures ever held a single conversation with Nick? Had any of the ones who ask me "How come?" been in a group who had screamed out "Do it!" as Nick was about to let go of the rafters and swing like a rag doll in front of them? I lasted three days in school.

Nick had been happy his whole life. He'd never had a bad day, I thought. He never seemed miserable or lonely, 'cause he had me. I thought he never minded that he was invisible. I'd always believed he never wanted to be like them, having basketball conversations and talking about what they did the night before. I guess that I was wrong about it all.

Wrong that he never minded that they thought he was a sad case 'cause his best friend was a girl with bad skin who couldn't form a social sentence. Wrong that it didn't make him sad the person he identified with most was a boy who'd died thirteen years before he was born, fighting a war that shouldn't have been. At thirteen when Nick found out about reincarnation, he decided his uncle had come back to the world as him. He really believed it. Believed it in his soul. Believed it more than anything he'd ever thought in his whole life, even believed it more than the thing about him being invisible.

[Now] I watch the world through a window of [a] Psychiatric Clinic for Adolescents, and the world only comes in and bothers me when I want it to. I've decided that it's not such a bad thing to be invisible. The thing that you have to be careful of, the thing that Nick never learned, is that you can't want to be anything else. You can't want to have more people who care. You have to be invisible on your own all by yourself. You can't even have a friend like me who loves you and thinks you're better than anything else.

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(sing lines from "Everybody is a Star" here – See links to song and lyrics at the end of this selection)

Nick got it wrong. Everybody isn't a star. . . maybe in a better world they could be. They could be. They really could be . . .

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Angela Johnson
Book: On the Fringe
ISBN: 978-0142500262
Publisher: Penguin Group
Date (Month/Year): March 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2014 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier - MS
KS State Qualifier

"Everybody is a Star" by Sly & the Family Stone
Listen to the song here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3-1s2qgDs_U
Read lyrics to the song here: http://www.metrolyrics.com/everybody-is-a-star-lyrics-sly-the-family-stone.html

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